RPIC REDESIGNING PEDAGOGY INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE 2026

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Reducing Test Anxiety Through Prequestioning

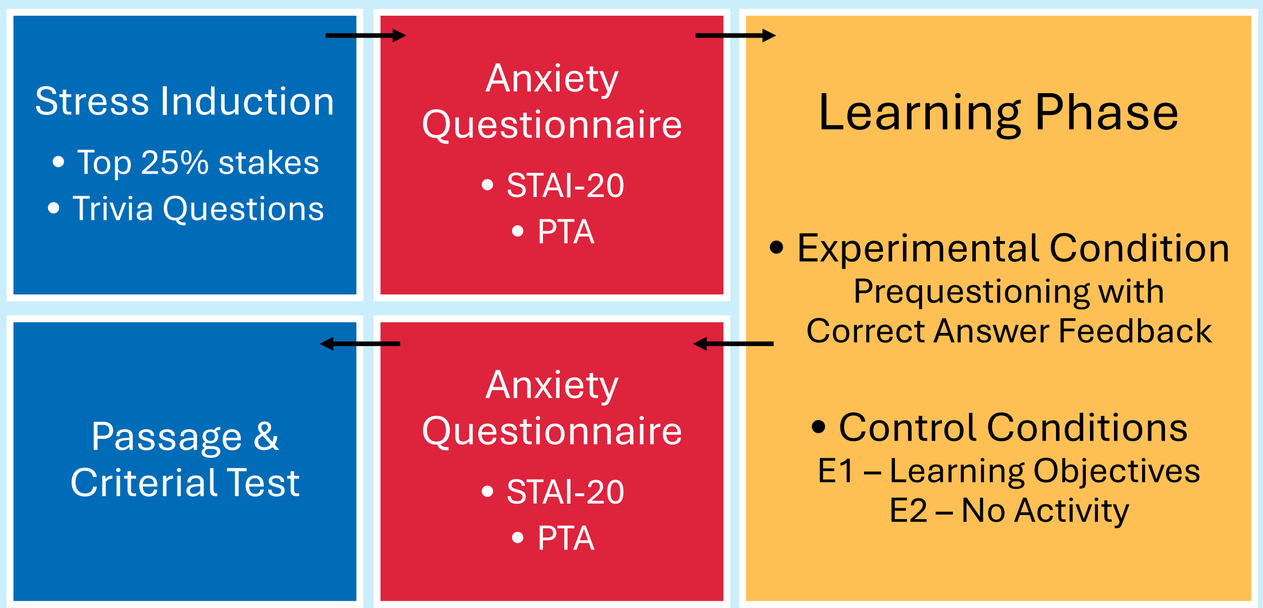
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Background

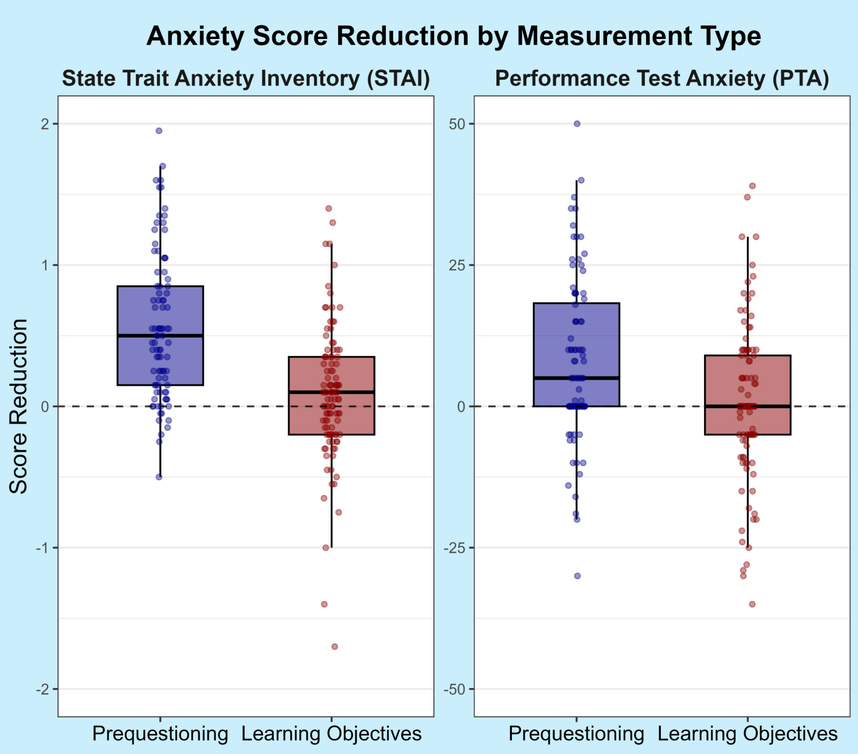
- *Test anxiety* is often associated with poor learning outcomes. As educational institutions increasingly utilize high-stakes testing, identifying strategies that simultaneously support effective learning and reduce test anxiety is essential.[1]
- *Prequestioning* (i.e., attempting questions **before** learning with feedback) has been shown to improve learning outcomes[2], but its potential affective benefits (i.e., reducing test anxiety) remain underexplored.
- Across two experiments, we sought to examine whether prequestioning could reduce test anxiety.



Methods

- 2-condition between-subjects design.
- Participants were recruited via the university's research pool (RP) and work scheme (NSWS).
- Test anxiety was assessed via the State Trait Anxiety Inventory (STAI-20)[3] and a self-developed Performance Test Anxiety (PTA) question.

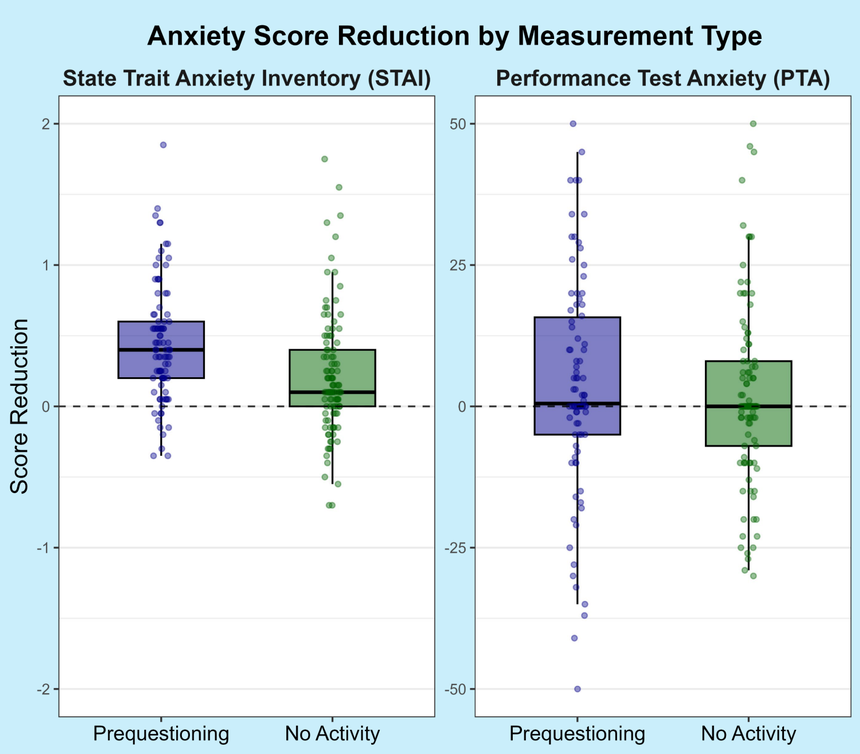
- **Experiment 1:** Prequestioning (Experimental) vs Learning Objectives (Active Control)
- **Experiment 2:** Prequestioning (Experimental) vs No Activity (Non-active Control)



Results

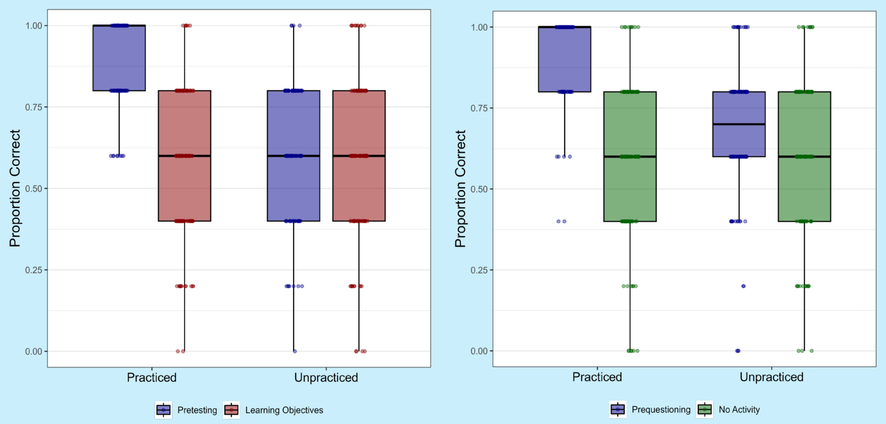
Prequestioning condition reported significantly greater anxiety score reductions compared to the Learning Objectives and No Activity conditions.

Prequestioning condition also performed better on the Criterial Test.



Summary & Implications

- These experiments **provide preliminary evidence that prequestioning reduces test anxiety** compared to learning objectives or no activity.
- We propose that prequestioning helps learners become familiar with test-like formats, improving their sense of preparation.
- Future work will extend this research to classroom settings, where tests occur naturally and are more likely to elicit authentic test anxiety.
- We encourage educators to utilize prequestioning not only for its learning benefits, but also for its potential to reduce student anxiety.



Further Information

REFERENCES
[1]Chakraborty, A. (2023). Exploring the Root Causes of Examination Anxiety: Effective Solutions and Recommendations. *International Journal of Science and Research (IJSR)*, *12*(2), 1096–1102.
[2]Pan, S. C., & Carpenter, S. K. (2023). Prequestioning and Pretesting Effects: A Review of Empirical Research, Theoretical Perspectives, and Implications for Educational Practice. *Educational Psychology Review*, *35*(4), 97.
[3]Spielberger, C. D., Gorsuch, R. L., & Lushene, R. E. (1983). Manual for the State-Trait Anxiety Inventory (STAI). *PaloAlto, CA: Consulting Psychologists Press*.

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